

make your movie look classy, or to create a flashback or 'dream sequence' scene within a larger home movie epic.

3. Rotate

There are several rotation effects, but they are not useful for video. However, they work great for photographs, and allow you to align your photos properly.

4. Speed

Slowing down or speeding up can be useful for creating comedy 'movies.' For example, you could make a fake kung-fu movie with your kids and use the speed-up effect to create rapid-motion fighting scenes. Likewise, the slow-down effect could be used to create the clichéd 'slow motion punch'.

Applying Effects

 To apply effects to your film, open up the Video Effects collection. You can preview each effect in the preview monitor by double-clicking the effect thumbnail. To apply the effect to a video clip, simply grab the effect and drop it onto the clip in the storyboard.

Another way to apply effects is by right-clicking on the clip and choosing 'Video effects.' This mode allows you to see exactly what effects are being used. This view is useful if you have to add or remove multiple effects to your clip.

Transitions

 WMM2 comes with a huge selection of transitions that you can place between your video clips. There are 60 transitions to choose from, ranging from simple fades to complex geometric shapes. When first presented with such a plethora of transition options, you may be tempted to use them judiciously throughout your video. For a home movie, that's fine; however, if you are trying to create a 'professional-looking' video, you may want to go easy on the transitions.

1. "Cut!"

This isn't really a transition, but a switch in movie clips: when one clip ends, the next one immediately begins. The timing of cuts is very important, and there are

many funny and amazing things you can do with careful timing. WMM2 makes it easy to cut your scenes by allowing you to 'trim' the ends of your video clips.

2. Fade

The fade is the most used transition. It is simply a cross-dissolve between two scenes, and in movies, typically occurs when the story changes locations.

3. Wipe

This effect is used less often than the fade, but implies the same thing—a change in location. This effect is more obvious than the fade. The wipe denotes a major change in location and even a change in time.

Adding Music To Your Video

 A music background can really spice up a home movie. Music is easy to apply on your computer with a program such as WMM2. In fact, this program has an audio track specifically for music; all you have to do is import a song and drop it onto the music track in the timeline.

After your song is in place, you can trim the end of the song—so that it's the same length as the video—and adjust the volume so it doesn't drown out your video.

WMM2 can import most sound formats. If you own a CD with a song you like, you can always import that song onto your computer using Windows Media Player.

Recording A Narration

 WMM2 makes it really easy to record a voice narration over your movie. The program even has an inbuilt recording wizard that allows you to record over a microphone while you watch a preview of your movie.

This feature is very useful, and allows you to quickly narrate descriptive videos. For example, if you are selling a house, you could film all the rooms and later record a running commentary to go with it. Another great use for a voice track is in creating picture slideshows. You could take pictures from your digital camera, lay them on

the WMM2 timeline, and then record a narration for your slideshow!

To use this function, you'll need a microphone. Fortunately, most cheap desk microphones work fine for voice recording. For the best results, you may want to invest in a headset microphone—the earphones will give you real-time feedback of what your voice sounds like. This allows you to announce clearly and correct for voice-popping and inadvertent mouth noises.

To use the voice track wizard, simply press the 'Narrate timeline' button located to the left of the timeline. When you click this button, the narration wizard will pop up, and give you some recording options. Most of these are pretty obvious; you can click 'Show more options' to see more recording choices. You'll need to pick your recording device (your sound card) and plug a microphone into your computer's microphone-in jack.

In the pop-up wizard is a microphone level bar that moves up and down as you speak. If this bar does not appear to be moving, your microphone may not be set up properly. Setting up a microphone for the first time can be frustrating, but here are the major things you should check.

1. Your microphone isn't set as the recording device: You may need to go into your sound properties panel, and make sure that your microphone is set as your recording device. You can also do this within WMM2's recording wizard.

2. The microphone boost is on or off:

If you find that your microphone sounds distorted or is too loud or soft, your microphone boost may be on or off respectively. You can find this option under 'Sound properties' under the 'Advanced settings' button. You can try altering this option, also called 'Mic 20dB up,' to get the best sound quality.

3. The sound isn't loud enough:

Make sure you're getting good

Bet You Didn't Know

Where Transitions Should Be Used

One place you might want to use fancy transitions is in a photo slideshow. WMM2 lets you import pictures from your digicam and lay them on your timeline as a 'video slideshow.' You can even add music or a descriptive voice track over these photos.

Because photos are static and non-moving, transitions are great because they add 'motion' to your movie.

sound levels within the voice wizard. Try to get the sound meter near the red, but not to the topmost red bar. If your sound is set too high, your voice will distort. You can also increase the voice track volume after you lay it down in your timeline.

Once you've got your microphone working, you can record your narration. The narration wizard will play your movie, and you can record your dialogue while watching the movie preview. When you are done talking, click 'Stop.' The wizard will try to save the voice track file onto your hard drive. You should save this audio file inside your project's main folder to keep your files organised.

WMM2 will automatically import your narration into your collections. To place it in your movie, simply drag the audio clip onto the timeline. You can then move or trim the ends of the voice track, and change the volume level with the volume button.

Using Both Narration And Music

 While it is very easy to add a music or voice narration to your movie, it is very hard to add *both* a music and voice track to the same movie. That's because WMM2 only comes with a single audio track, which means you have to choose between one or the other. However, if you really need both audio tracks, there are a couple of tricks you can do, though each of these workarounds has its own problems.